

24.1 Look at A opposite. Read these statements and answer the questions.

Rob:

I got his new book the day it was published.

Matthew:

My new tablet is great: it's easy to use, it looks good, and it was cheap.

Clara:

This phone has features that no other phone has yet; it's amazing.

Julian:

Apparently, it was invented by a Russian scientist, who worked on it for ten years.

Who is talking about ...

- 1 something that is at the cutting edge of technology?
- 2 something that was hot off the press?
- 3 something that pushes the right buttons?
- 4 something that was the brainchild of someone?

24.2 Rewrite the underlined part of each sentence using the word in brackets.

- 1 I try my best to do my job well, but sometimes I feel as if I'm just an unimportant person in a massive organisation. [MACHINE]
- 2 I don't want to do anything to prevent your plan from working, but I think you should apply for official permission first. [SPANNER]
- 3 I worry sometimes that we're just wasting time doing something someone has already done in our research. [WHEEL]
- 4 I'm afraid I couldn't print the document; our printer is not working properly. [BLINK]
- 5 There was a power failure and everything suddenly stopped working. [HAYWIRE]
- 6 She should be able to write a simple text message. I mean, it's not a difficult thing to do, is it? [SCIENCE]
- 7 I think we're a long way away from finding a cure for this terrible disease. [LIGHT]
- 8 Why change the system? If it works OK, we don't need to do anything! [BROKE]

24.3 Choose the correct answer.

- 1 If you oil the wheels of something, you a) make something happen very suddenly
b) make it easier for something to happen c) stop something happening.
- 2 A gas guzzler is a) a type of cooker b) a person who drinks a lot c) a type of car.
- 3 If you set the wheels in motion for something, you a) cause it to start b) create complications for it c) cause it to stop.
- 4 If a machine is on the blink, it a) is working correctly b) is not working at all
c) is working, but not correctly.

24.4 Here are some errors made with idioms by candidates in advanced-level exams. Can you correct them?

- 1 My school was new. We had all kinds of cutting-hedge technology.
- 2 Suddenly, everything went hayware, and there was complete chaos.
- 3 She felt she was just a cog in the wheel and that no one ever noticed her.
- 4 The city council set the wheel to turn for the construction of the new park.

A

Idioms from film and theatre reviews

The show had the audience **rolling in the aisles**¹.

The plot will **keep you on the edge of your seat**⁴.

The finale **brought the house down**².

His dramatic performance **sent shivers down my spine**⁵.

Helena Good **stole the show**³ with a fantastic performance.

¹ laughing a lot ² made the audience laugh or clap a lot; was extremely successful ³ got all the attention and praise at an event or performance ⁴ keep you excited and interested in what happens next ⁵ was very moving

B

Talking about books

Ben: I read that novel that Laura recommended. I eventually managed to **wade through**¹ all 400 pages, but I didn't like it very much. It was really **heavy going**². It's not what I would call a **page-turner**³!

Nina: Yeah. The critics in the Sunday papers certainly **did a hatchet job on**⁴ it.

Ben: Well, it's pretty easy to **pick holes in**⁵ the plot. I didn't think it was at all convincing.

Nina: Mind you, I could never write a short story, let alone a novel.

Ben: Yes, it's much easier to **be an armchair critic**⁶, isn't it?

¹ finish reading something, but with difficulty ² difficult to read or understand ³ a book that is so exciting that you have to read it quickly ⁴ criticised strongly and cruelly ⁵ find mistakes in; criticise ⁶ criticise, but without any personal expertise in what is being criticised (You can also say 'armchair traveller' and 'armchair gardener').

C

An actor's career



Entertainment



Portia Cole had always dreamt of **having her name in lights**¹. At school she was a **leading light**² of the drama club, and she spent all her free time **treading the boards**³. Portia's tendency to **play to the gallery**⁴ meant she was quickly noticed when she started acting professionally. When she got the opportunity to take over the leading role in a popular new **crowd-puller**⁵ in a major London theatre, she was **waiting in the wings**⁶, ready and eager to **take centre stage**⁷. She was surprised to feel very nervous before her opening night. However, all her friends and relatives assured her that it would be **all right on the night**⁸, and it was! The audience and the critics loved her, and her career was well and truly launched.

¹ being famous ² an important member ³ acting on stage (in the theatre) ⁴ behave in a way to make people admire or support her; often slightly disapproving ⁵ something attracting a lot of attention and interest ⁶ ready to become important (this idiom is often used in non-theatrical contexts too, e.g. 'Investors are **waiting in the wings**, ready to act if the business is sold'.) ⁷ become the most important person in the play (this idiom is often used in non-theatrical contexts too, e.g. 'Education **took centre stage** in the new political manifesto'.) ⁸ without problems on the day of the actual performance